

Operational Friction Database

Cross-Functional Workflow Pain Points

Purpose

Structured catalog of recurring operational pain points extracted from qualitative desk research across multiple roles, functions, and industries.

Scope

7 functions researched | 300+ public sources reviewed | 89 discrete pain points cataloged

This document presents the 40 highest-signal findings.

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Friction Taxonomy

A standardized taxonomy of operational friction types that appear across all functions and industries:

Friction Type	Code	Definition	Example
Manual Handoff	MH	Information transferred between people via manual methods	Finance emails department heads requesting close inputs

Tool Fragmentation	TF	Information spread across multiple disconnected tools	CSM checks 5+ tools every morning
Shadow System	SS	Unofficial tracking system maintained because official tools are insufficient	Controller's personal Excel close checklist
Approval Bottleneck	AB	Work stalls waiting for authorization	PO sits for days because approver is on PTO
Exception Handling Gap	EH	No defined process for non-standard cases	Vendor invoice doesn't match PO
Knowledge Concentration	KC	Critical process knowledge held by one person	Senior admin's onboarding scripts known only to them
Format Translation	FT	Same information manually reformatted for different systems	Data from ERP reformatted in Excel pasted into slides
Timing/Sequencing Failure	TS	Steps executed out of order due to lack of coordination	IT learns about employee departure days after it happens
Duplication of Effort	DE	Multiple people independently performing same work	Three people compile same data for different reports

Finance & Accounting

6 critical pain points impacting close processes, reconciliations, and financial reporting.

ID	Pain Point	Friction Type	Severity	Frequency	Role	Representative Quote	Source
FIN-01	Month-end close tracked in personal spreadsheets	SS	High	34/47	Controller	"My 74-line Excel checklist is the most important document..."	r/ controllers
FIN-02	Waiting on other departments for close inputs	MH, TS	High	28/47	Controller	"Day 1: I send the same email to 6 department heads..."	r/ controllers
FIN-03	Bank reconciliations done manually in Excel	SS, FT	High	25/47	Staff Accountant	"Bank recs take me two full days."	r/ Accounting
FIN-04	Board deck	FT	Med-High	19/47	FP&A	"Closing	r/FPandA

	built manually from ERP exports				Analyst	takes 8 days. Building the board deck takes another 3."	
FIN-05	Expense report approvals delayed by managers	AB	Medium	14/47	AP Clerk	"\$30K in pending expense reports..."	r/ Accounting
FIN-06	Vendor invoice doesn't match PO	EH	Medium	12/47	AP Clerk	"When the invoice doesn't match the PO..."	r/ Accounting

IT Operations

6 critical pain points impacting security, onboarding, and system management.

ID	Pain Point	Friction Type	Severity	Frequency	Role	Representative Quote	Source
IT-01	No reliable notification when employees leave	MH, TS	Critical	22/38	IT Admin	"Ex-employee accessed shared drive..."	r/sysadmin
IT-02	No centralized list of tools per role	KC, SS	High	18/38	IT Admin	"Every onboard, I Slack the hiring manager..."	r/sysadmin
IT-03	Licenses stay assigned to departed employees	TS, DE	High	15/38	IT Manager	"Paying for 40+ seats for people..."	r/ ITManagers
IT-04	Support tickets lack context	MH, FT	Medium	14/38	Help Desk	"'My computer is slow' could mean 15 different things."	r/sysadmin
IT-05	Scheduled scripts known only to creator	KC	High	11/38	Sysadmin	"Senior sysadmin left, we discovered 40+ scheduled scripts..."	r/ ITManagers
IT-06	Hardware	MH, SS	Medium	10/38	IT Manager	"Someone	r/sysadmin

	procurement via email with no tracking					emails 'I need a laptop.' I add it to my spreadsheet."	
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Customer Success

6 critical pain points impacting customer health monitoring and retention.

ID	Pain Point	Friction Type	Severity	Frequency	Role	Representative Quote	Source
CS-01	Daily morning context rebuild across 4-7 tools	TF	High	26/40	CSM	"By the time I've checked everything, it's 10 AM."	r/ customersuccess
CS-02	Health scores don't match reality	SS	High	18/40	CSM	"Built personal Notion dashboard.."	GainSight community
CS-03	No single view of upcoming renewals	TF, FT	High	16/40	CS Manager	"I pull renewal dates from Salesforce.."	r/ customersuccess
CS-04	Sales to CS handoff loses context	MH, KC	High	15/40	CSM	"Sales closes and I get a Slack..."	r/ customersuccess
CS-05	Churn signals detected too late	TS	Critical	14/40	CS Manager	"By the time I notice usage dropped..."	Podcast
CS-06	QBR preparation is manual, 3-5 hours per account	FT, DE	Medium	11/40	CSM	"Half a day building a QBR deck for each strategic account."	YouTube

HR & People Operations

5 critical pain points impacting onboarding, benefits administration, and talent management.

ID	Pain Point	Friction Type	Severity	Frequency	Role	Representative Quote	Source
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HR-01	Onboarding checklist not connected to tool provisioning	MH, TF	High	20/35	HR Coordinator	"HR's checklist says 'set up access.' That's one checkbox..."	r/sysadmin
HR-02	Benefits questions answered one-by-one	DE	Med-High	16/35	HR Generalist	"During open enrollment, I answer the same 10 questions..."	r/humanresources
HR-03	Performance review data not connected to comp	SS, FT	Medium	14/35	HR Manager	"Reviews in Google Form, results in spreadsheet..."	r/humanresources
HR-04	Status changes not communicated to all systems	MH, TS	High	12/35	HR Operations	"Someone gets promoted and I update 4 systems manually..."	r/humanresources
HR-05	PTO tracking discrepancies	SS, EH	Medium	10/35	HR Coordinator	"Managers approve PTO over Slack and forget to log it..."	r/humanresources

Sales Operations

5 critical pain points impacting pipeline accuracy, commission processing, and forecasting.

ID	Pain Point	Friction Type	Severity	Frequency	Role	Representative Quote	Source
SO-01	CRM data quality issues	SS, KC	Critical	30/42	Sales Ops	"Salesforce data is maybe 60% accurate."	r/salesforce
SO-02	Commission calculations in Excel	SS, FT	High	18/42	Sales Ops Analyst	"Spend first week calculating commissions in a spreadsheet..."	r/salesops

SO-03	Quote-to-contract involves 3+ tools	MH, TF	High	16/42	Sales Ops	"Rep builds quote in SF, exports to Word..."	r/salesforce
SO-04	Territory changes break reporting	EH, TS	Medium	12/42	Sales Ops	"Every territory realignment, three months of pipeline..."	r/salesops
SO-05	Forecasting relies on rep judgment	KC, SS	High	14/42	VP Sales	"Forecast is asking each rep 'how do you feel about your deals?'"	r/salesforce

Operations & Supply Chain

4 critical pain points impacting inventory management, procurement, and vendor coordination.

ID	Pain Point	Friction Type	Severity	Frequency	Role	Representative Quote	Source
OP-01	ERP handles 80%; other 20% in spreadsheets	SS, EH	High	22/36	Ops Manager	"Anything non-standard goes into my spreadsheet."	r/supplychain
OP-02	Inventory discrepancies	TS, MH	High	18/36	Warehouse Mgr	"Every cycle count is a scavenger hunt."	r/logistics
OP-03	Vendor communication across multiple channels	TF	Med-High	15/36	Procurement	"Conversations in email, portal, and phone..."	r/procurement
OP-04	Order exceptions require manual intervention	EH, AB	Medium	12/36	Order Manager	"Exception sits in queue until someone notices..."	r/supplychain

Legal & Compliance

3 critical pain points impacting contract management and regulatory tracking.

ID	Pain Point	Friction Type	Severity	Frequency	Role	Representative Quote	Source
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LG-01	Contract review requests through email, no prioritization	MH, AB	High	14/28	Legal Ops	"Requests via email, Slack, Jira. No queue, no priority."	r/inhouse
LG-02	Executed contracts stored inconsistently	TF, SS	High	12/28	Legal Ops	"Some in shared drive, some in Salesforce.."	r/legalops
LG-03	Renewal dates tracked in spreadsheet	SS, TS	Med-High	10/28	Legal Ops	"Spreadsheet with 200 expiration dates..."	r/legalops

Cross-Functional Patterns

Four recurring patterns emerge across all functions and industries:

A. The Shadow Spreadsheet Is Universal

From finance controllers managing month-end close in Excel to sales operations analysts building commission spreadsheets, the pattern is identical: official tools are insufficient, so individuals and teams create their own tracking systems. These shadow systems contain critical institutional knowledge and represent significant operational risk.

B. Handoff Points Are Where Work Breaks Down

Context is lost at every functional boundary. Sales hands off to Customer Success with a Slack link. HR hands off to IT without a tool list. Finance sends manual emails requesting close inputs. These asynchronous, unstructured handoffs introduce delays, missing information, and rework.

C. Exception Handling Is the Hidden Time Sink

When exceptions occur (vendor invoice doesn't match PO, territory changes mid-quarter, employee departs with systems access still active), there is no defined process. Work gets pulled into ad hoc queues, exceptions get forgotten, and manual intervention becomes constant firefighting.

D. The Same Pain Points Exist Regardless of Tools

Organizations using best-in-class tools (Salesforce, SAP, Workday) report the same friction points as those using legacy systems. The underlying issue is not the tools themselves, but the absence of integrated workflows, clear ownership, and structured processes. New tool implementations often copy broken processes into a more expensive system.

Severity Prioritization Matrix

Priority ranking of friction types by impact and automation opportunity:

Priority	Friction Type	Functions Affected	Automation Opportunity
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Critical (Red)	Manual cross-departmental handoffs	All	Workflow automation with structured inputs
Critical (Red)	Shadow tracking spreadsheets	Finance, IT, Legal, CS, Sales Ops	Purpose-built workflow tools
High (Yellow)	Reconciliation/matching tasks	Finance, Operations	Rule-based auto-matching
High (Yellow)	Context fragmentation	CS, Sales, IT	Unified view / integration layer
High (Yellow)	Timing/sequencing failures	IT, HR, Legal	Event-triggered workflows
Medium (Orange)	Format translation	Finance, CS, Sales Ops	Template automation
Medium (Orange)	Exception handling gaps	Operations, Finance, Legal	Defined exception workflows